

What I liked

- Absolutely hassle-free and all the hardware functioned out-of-the-box.
- Some bits and pieces are still in beta, but the underlying approach of making websites and software applications feel the same, as well as introducing users to new ones, is really innovative.
- Has the heart of Debian.
- Can easily be converted into a bootable USB.
- Multiple styles of application installation.

What I am skeptical about

- It relies too heavily on Ubuntu's netbook remix interface, to the extent that it still seems to be Ubuntu. I'd like to see the overall functionality integrate further before I'd call this its own markedly different initiative.
- Downloaded applications are organised for you and cannot be reorganised.
- Lousy power management.
- If you add the JoliCloud APT repository to the sources list in a regular Ubuntu 9.04 desktop install, you can easily install packages for various Prism launchers without even having to bother installing the JoliCloud distro or using its Web service. This gives you roughly the same experience minus the slightly creepy social networking features. So, what's the big deal?

JoliCloud's launcher and user interface are entirely based on UNR, but it has a few minor theming customisations that differentiate it aesthetically. The most significant feature of JoliCloud is its unique Web service that runs in a Prism shell and integrates with the rest of the environment. It provides an elegant HTML-based interface for update management, an application directory, and some simplistic social networking features.

The JoliCloud service's Dashboard interface shows you notifications from the service and information about pending updates. Users can initiate a system update from the JoliCloud dashboard interface, but the actual update process is handled by Ubuntu's standard package update tool.

An OS gone social

This is the most intriguing part of JoliCloud that differentiates it from the rest of the operating systems. While the JoliCloud servers keep the data about the software that is being installed by you, it is also possible to connect with various other JoliCloud users and stay updated on the kind of software they are using. Yes, this is both exciting and scary at the same time. While privacy could be a serious concern among users, it is also a great way to get introduced to new apps and services.

As Tariq Krim said, "You are right. We are dropping the netbook remix for a newer interface and we are going to improve the social features. We also see the social OS as a great way to do support as

you can ask friends who have the same stuff or the same machine."

This should provide a great way to get to know the best applications when the list of tools eventually grows too big for users to easily find their way. It's also a good way for JoliCloud to analyse who is using what, and on what type of machine (this reminds me a bit of Wakooopa). It could prove beneficial for JoliCloud to integrate more social features in the future, like the ability to communicate directly with other users or instantly share applications, reviews, screenshots, etc, on the multitude of social networking services out there.

One of the big draws of JoliCloud is that it takes this list of apps you have installed and backs it up. If you have multiple computers running JoliCloud that share the same account, it syncs up those apps, including any log-ins or shared data. This places less importance on what hardware you're using, so you can hop from machine to machine and get right back to what you were doing, on any one of the systems.

Bundled software

Some of the software that come bundled with JoliCloud are:

1. Mozilla Firefox
2. Evolution
3. Cheese
4. Empathy
5. F-Spot
6. Transmission
7. Rhythmbox

In short, almost anything and everything that a netbook might need, is pre-installed with the OS.

Compatibility issues

True to the Ubuntu charm, JoliCloud worked perfectly with every netbook we tested it on. All the drivers and devices got installed and could be used out-of-the-box. However, we could not make it presentable on the 11.6" (29.5 cm) Acer Aspire 751H because the resolution could not be changed from 1024x768 and the icons looked extremely stretched. Other than that, it was the most hassle-free OS we tested.